

WEEKLY BUSINESS SESSION – July 8, 2026

5:30 p.m. – Anne Basker Auditorium
600 N.W. Sixth Street, Grants Pass, OR 97526

Present: Ron A. Smith, Chair-Commissioner; Colene M. Martin, Vice-Chair-Commissioner and Gary L. Richardson, Commissioner, Nikole Guzman, Recorder

These are meeting minutes only. Only text enclosed in quotation marks reports a speaker's exact words.

Pursuant to notice through the media and in conformance with the Public Meeting Law, Ron Smith, Chair, called the meeting to order at 5:30 p.m. followed by the Pledge of Allegiance.

Items discussed were as follows:

1. **CALL MEETING TO ORDER:** Pursuant to notice through the media and in conformance with the Public Meeting Law, Ron Smith, Chair, called the meeting to order at 5:30 p.m.
2. **DECLARE A POTENTIAL CONFLICT OF INTEREST:** The commissioners reserved their right to declare a potential conflict of interest.
3. **Public Hearing: Second Reading of Ordinance No. 2026-001; An Ordinance Amending Chapter 2.05 of the County Code Relating to the Meetings of the Board of Commissioners**

Commissioner Smith opened the public hearing at 5:31 p.m.

Commissioner Martin made a motion to Ordinance No. 2026-001 read by title only. Seconded by Commissioner Richardson. Upon roll call, Commissioner Richardson – yes, Commissioner Martin – yes, Commissioner Smith – yes. Motion carried 3-0.

Wally Hicks, County Legal Counsel, presented the proposed ordinance and explained that it removes outdated language within Chapter 2.05 relating specifically to executive sessions while retaining references requiring the Board to conduct emergency and executive sessions in accordance with the Oregon Public Meetings Law and the Josephine County Charter. Mr. Hicks explained that relying upon state law and the Charter provides greater flexibility as public meeting laws continue to evolve through legislative changes, judicial decisions, and Attorney General guidance. Commissioners discussed the proposal and agreed that referencing governing law rather than duplicating statutory language within County Code would improve long-term consistency and reduce the need for future amendments.

Commissioner Smith opened the floor to Public Testimony: (Each person given Three (3) Minutes to speak):
None heard.

Commissioner Richardson commented that the amendment would provide the Board with additional flexibility when conducting executive sessions while maintaining compliance with applicable law. Commissioners expressed support for simplifying the County Code without altering the Board's legal obligations.

Commissioner Richardson made a motion to adopt Ordinance No. 2026-001, Seconded by Commissioner Martin. Upon roll call, Commissioner Richardson – yes, Commissioner Martin – yes, Commissioner Smith – yes. Motion carried 3-0.

Public Hearing closed at 5:34 p.m.

4. **Public Hearing: In the Matter of Annexations to the Josephine Community Library District by Petition of Landowner without Election**

Order Number Petitioner
2026-029 DRAKE LOVING TRUST

Assessor Map/Tax Lot Acres
36-05-29-D0-003401-00 5.00

2026-030 CARLSON, DAPHNE & DOWNES, SKYLAR**36-05-04-00-000902-00 7.97**

Commissioner Smith opened the public hearing at 5:36 p.m.

Commissioner Smith opened the floor to Public Testimony: (Each person given Three (3) Minutes to speak):
None

Commissioner Martin made a motion to approve Board Oder 2026-029, Seconded by Commissioner Richardson. Upon roll call, Commissioner Richardson – yes, Commissioner Martin – yes, Commissioner Smith – yes. Motion carried 3-0

Commissioner Martin made a motion to approve Board Oder 2026-030, Seconded by Commissioner Richardson. Upon roll call, Commissioner Richardson – yes, Commissioner Martin – yes, Commissioner Smith – yes. Motion carried 3-0

Public Hearing closed at 5:36 p.m.

5. **REQUESTS/COMMENTS FROM CITIZENS:** *(Each person will be given three (3) minutes to speak)*
Stephen Fitch, Josephine County resident, addressed the Board regarding concerns he has previously raised involving alleged retaliation, constitutional rights, and legal proceedings involving local governmental entities. Mr. Fitch stated that he believes his constitutional rights have been violated and advised that, absent resolution of those concerns, he intends to pursue the matter in federal court.

Jay Meredith, representing American Mineral Research, commented on the County's review of the Mining Ordinance. Mr. Meredith stated that, in his opinion, the existing ordinance generally remains functional and suggested that previous Boards failed to fully implement its provisions rather than the ordinance itself being deficient. He encouraged the Board to consider recommendations previously developed by the Mining Advisory Committee and emphasized the potential economic benefits and future revenue opportunities associated with responsible mineral development on County-owned lands.

Tamra Martin, Josephine County Fairgrounds Director, provided an update regarding preparations for the 2026 Josephine County Fair. Ms. Martin encouraged community participation in competitive exhibits, reviewed registration deadlines, highlighted youth livestock auction activities, and summarized the entertainment schedule, including the rodeo, Clay Walker concert, monster truck events, children's activities, and other attractions. She also noted that fair admission would remain free, with complimentary shuttle service available for attendees.

Michael Cope, Josephine County resident, discussed the historical significance of mineral resources within Josephine County and shared his long-standing research involving local geology and mineral development. Mr. Cope encouraged the Board to continue evaluating opportunities for responsible mineral development on County-owned lands as a potential long-term revenue source supporting essential County services.

BOARD MAY REVIEW PUBLIC COMMENTS/QUESTIONS:

6. **APPROVAL OF CONSENT CALENDAR:**

- a. **Minutes** *(Draft minutes are available for viewing in the Board's Office)*

General Meeting – June 30, 2026

Admin Workshop – June 30, 2026

Weekly Business Session – July 1, 2026

Executive Session – July 2, 2026

Admin Workshop – July 2, 2026

Fair Board Meeting – May 19, 2026

Board Journal – May 2026

Commissioner Richardson made a motion to approve the Consent Calendar, seconded by Commissioner Martin. Upon roll call, Commissioner Richardson – yes, Commissioner Martin – yes, Commissioner Smith – yes. Motion carried 3-0.

7. **OTHER: (ORS 192.640(1))** “. . . notice shall include a list of the principal subjects anticipated to be considered at the meeting, but this requirement shall not limit the ability of a governing body to consider additional subjects.”)

8. **ANNOUNCEMENTS: MATTERS FROM COMMISSIONERS:**

Commissioner Richardson presented updates available through the County Finance Department webpage, highlighting newly published Full-Time Equivalent (FTE) staffing information and monthly public disbursement reports. He explained that the reports provide transparency regarding County staffing levels and financial expenditures and allow the public to review County disbursements dating back several years. Commissioner Martin noted that Finance staff recently reviewed invoices exceeding the County's \$50,000 approval threshold and found that relatively few expenditures exceed that amount. She stated that Commissioners receive information regarding those larger expenditures and emphasized the Board's commitment to making decisions based upon verified financial information rather than speculation. Chair Smith reminded residents that Josephine County remains under a drought declaration and encouraged everyone to exercise caution throughout the fire season to reduce the risk of wildfires. He also expressed appreciation that no significant fires occurred during the Independence Day holiday weekend

Weekly Business Session adjourned at 6:03 p.m.



Nikole Guzman, Recorder